Late last month, when Abhishek Bachchan returned from a screening of his latest film *Dasvi* (streaming on Netflix from April 7), he felt pleased with the final product. At 4am, high on adrenaline and unable to sleep, he decided to pour his feelings into a note. By morning, it was up on Instagram. "I've always been very reticent to speak about my films, borderline apologetic about my work," read one of the lines. It's not often that actors are honest about their frailties, but for Bachchan, that's a pivotal part of being in the profession. "We have chosen to bare our deepest secrets for millions to see and judge," he says. "I believe actors are some of the bravest people I know, for it takes immense courage to portray an emotion as genuinely as possible."

Few express that strength and courage more than Abhishek's father, Amitabh Bachchan, inarguably one of the greatest actors of Hindi cinema. In his 22-year-long career, Abhishek has often been asked—at times forced—to emulate him. It took only a few attempts for the actor to realise this was an exercise in futility. "There's a reason he is who he is. There can't be [another] one like him. How can I be another Amitabh Bachchan? How can I compare myself to my idol?" he asks. As Abhishek came to terms with these comparisons and the pressure of legacy, he says he found comfort each time he focused on his own expectations of himself rather than those of others: "Somewhere deep in the recesses of the soul, you want to do things differently. You need to have the confidence to rely on and act upon the voice within you. Once you do that, it is very liberating."

COLLABORATING WITH A NEW GENERATION OF FILMMAKERS HAS ALLOWED ABHISHEK BACHCHAN TO REINVENT, ADAPT AND EVOLVE



OUTSIDE THE BOX
Abhishek Bachchan in *Dasvi*

Collaborating with a new generation of filmmakers—Diya Annapurna Ghosh, the 26-year-old director of his previous release, *Bob Biswas* (2021, ZEE5), and Tushar Jalota, newcomer director of *Dasvi*—has also afforded Bachchan a rare, new freedom. "They are not intimidated by you. They have no preconceived notions and [are] very clear about what they want to do," he says. "It aids people like me, who have been around longer, to reinvent, adapt and evolve. You feed off the energy. I have really learned so much in the past couple of years."

To play Ganga Ram Chaudhary in *Dasvi*, a politician who decides to clear his Class X examinations while lodged in prison, Bachchan learned the Haryanvi dialect. Also starring Yami Gautam and Nimrat Kaur, the social comedy highlights how education "can open up your thinking and offer a broader spectrum to life", says Bachchan. *Dangal's* (2016) dialect coach Sunita Sharma helped him bring nuance to the character with her insights on the Jat way of life and, also, that typical Jat swagger. "I wanted to understand how these guys think and where they are coming from. She told me to take time [delivering the lines]," says Bachchan. "I didn't just want to mug up [the lines]. It had to be something you imbibe only then it comes naturally." Bachchan swore by something his father said, a quote that he shared with Chaudhary: "Don't walk around with the attitude that

BACHCHAN'S BEST

BLUFFMASTER! (2005) *Netflix*

Five years after he had burst onto the scene with *Refugee*, Bachchan was seen using movies like *Bluffmaster!* to trademark his own variety of cool. Here he played Roy Kapoor, a suave conman who gives up his swindling ways when love makes him see value in the straight and narrow.





GURU (2007) *Netflix*

In 2004, Mani Ratnam, it is said, discovered the actor in Abhishek with *Yuva*, but it was three years later that the director finally made the junior Bachchan a star. Loosely based on the life of Dhirubhai Ambani, *Guru* saw Abhishek deliver a performance that was both convincing and powerful.

MANMARZIYAN (2018) *JioCinema*

